

Commons Bonds

By Chris Winn

I.

I did not grimace. Not once.

My wife lay in our bed in Savannah with a wound vac affixed to her abdomen and an ileostomy bag she could not change herself. Her intestines had bound up during pregnancy, starved of blood, they ruptured, her body septic. Her heart stopped on a hospital table and had then been restarted. She had, in the most literal sense, died and come back, and she was now processing the emotional reality of that while recovering from the surgery that had saved her and our son.

The insurance company only agreed to cover a home health aide for half of her dressing changes. The other half fell to me. I had never changed a surgical dressing. I had never emptied an ileostomy bag. I had spent twenty years in healthcare IT — co-founding a company that built the electronic patient registry and clinical trial system for Johns Hopkins, consulting for NASA and NIH. None of that prepared me for this. But I looked at her, this person who had literally died and been brought back, who was processing the fact of her own death while also trying to be a mother to a newborn, and I understood what she needed. I understood something that I suspect most people understand when the moment arrives: what she needed was not a nurse. Not a technician. What she needed was someone who would not flinch. Someone whose compassion was limitless. Someone who would be her rock while she figured out how to live in a body that had betrayed her and then been stitched back together. I'm intensely empathic. I knew I could give her that. So I did.

And then paternal leave ran out.

A deal came through — the kind that funds the mortgage, keeps the healthcare active, the kind you do not say no to. So I got on a plane. So I flew to a client site. So I did what I had spent my career learning to do, which was to be valuable enough to justify my compensation. The house was beautiful. It was not more beautiful than my family. When I look back in the rearview mirror of time, the house isn't what I miss.

I want to be careful here, because what I am about to name is not a complaint about a bad employer. My employer was not cruel. My colleagues were not indifferent. The system that sent me to an airport while my wife recovered from death and my infant son needed his father was not designed by villains. It was designed by no one at all. It simply captured the value I could produce, and the cost of my absence — the strain on a marriage already buckling under the weight of trauma, the hours my wife spent alone with a wound she could barely manage — was

severed from any ledger. It did not appear in a quarterly report. It was not carried by anyone who had profited from my labor. It was mine alone to bear.

I did not have the language for this then. I do now. The value was captured. The cost was severed. And the obligation to my wife, to my son, to the version of my life that required me to be physically present — was mine alone to carry. Not because anyone chose to be cruel. But because no structure existed to make it otherwise.

This essay is about that structure, or rather, the absence of it. It is about what happens when value is extracted from people, communities, and resources, and the costs of that extraction are cut free and left for someone else to carry. It is about a missing instrument in our economic thinking that allows this to happen at every scale, from a single family to an entire region to the planet itself. And it is about what it might look like to begin building something different.

II. The Mechanism Named

Let me start with a mine.

In the coalfields of central Appalachia, the mechanism I am describing has been operating for more than a century. When Congress passed the Surface Mining Control and Reclamation Act in 1977, it required coal companies to post bonds guaranteeing that when extraction was finished, the land would be restored. The principle is elegant. The practice has been catastrophic.

Across Appalachia, bonds fall [\\$3.7 to \\$6 billion](#) short of addressing actual reclamation costs. Self-bonding allows operators to get permits by merely claiming they can cover cleanup, without [transferring cash into secured accounts](#). Bond amounts are calculated at flat per-acre rates bearing [no relationship to actual costs](#). In West Virginia, mine-specific bonds cover only ten percent of projected reclamation costs. And as coal companies declare bankruptcy with increasing regularity, [they take their money and run](#) from their responsibilities, leaving taxpayers on the hook. Meanwhile, Congress has [proposed raiding \\$500 million from abandoned mine land cleanup funds](#) even as communities continue living with the toxic legacy — rare cancers, widespread black lung, poisoned waterways.

I want to name what is happening here with precision, because precision is what has been missing.

There is a mechanism older than capitalism, present in feudalism and colonialism and Soviet industrial planning and every other system that has ever concentrated power, in which value is extracted from a person, a community, or a resource, and the costs generated by that extraction are deliberately severed from the entity that profited and transferred to others. I call this mechanism *cost severance*. It is not a market failure. It is not an externality in the economist's polite sense. It is a structural feature of how extraction operates when no countervailing force prevents it.

The word *severance* is deliberate. It carries the violence of cutting — a deliberate act that separates things that were once connected. Profit and the cost of producing it were, in any honest accounting, joined. Cost severance is the act that cuts them apart. And it carries an ironic echo: severance is also what you receive when you are let go.

Cost severance is not capitalism's invention. Capitalism is merely its most efficient current vehicle. Feudal lords extracted agricultural surplus while severing the costs of famine to the peasantry. Colonial empires extracted raw materials while severing ecological destruction to colonized populations. Soviet planners extracted industrial output from the Aral Sea basin while severing the costs of its desiccation to the communities that depended on it. The system changes. The mechanism does not.

Once you see cost severance in a coal mine, you see it everywhere. In the pension-to-401(k) shift, where the employer's obligation to fund retirement was severed and transferred to the individual worker. In the 2008 financial crisis, where banks designed toxic mortgage instruments, collected fees, distributed the risk, and when the instruments collapsed, received [\\$700 billion in public rescue](#) while [ten million families lost their homes](#). And cost severance can operate inside the body itself. Journalist Katy Butler documented [how Medicare reimbursed roughly \\$12,500](#) for the pacemaker implant that consigned her elderly, stroke-damaged father to years of profound decline — while the long office conversation that might have spared him, a discussion of treatment alternatives, [was worth \\$54](#). His elderly wife worked long hours as his unpaid caregiver; labor for which no compensation existed. The extraction does not stop at the grave. It is organized around reaching into it.

III. The \$100 Barrel

There is a barrel of oil underground. Someone puts a price on it. Call it one hundred dollars. That price reflects what a buyer will pay today: a function of supply, demand, refining costs, and speculative futures. It is a number generated by the present, for the present. It does not account for what the earth permanently loses.

When that barrel is extracted, the community absorbs environmental disruption and contamination. But there is a deeper cost that no existing framework addresses: the barrel is gone. Not consumed the way a forest is consumed, where sustainable harvest is possible. Not depleted the way a fishery is depleted, where recovery can occur. The barrel is liquidated. Permanently. Every future generation will never have access to that barrel or the energy it contained.

I call this *residual commons value*: the worth of what was permanently foreclosed.

No existing economic framework prices this. Classical economics assumes substitutability — that technology will provide alternatives — but this is an assumption, not a guarantee. Marxist economics addresses [who captures surplus value](#) but not the permanent foreclosure of the resource itself. Ostrom's Nobel-winning [commons governance](#) is brilliant for renewable

resources but a barrel of oil cannot be sustainably harvested; it can only be extracted once. The community is not managing a commons. It is liquidating one. Herman Daly's [ecological economics](#) correctly insists the economy is a subsystem of the biosphere, but even Daly does not produce a price for permanent foreclosure. [Hartwick's Rule](#) says communities should invest extraction rents in reproducible capital — [Norway's sovereign wealth fund](#) being the best application — but a barrel converted into financial assets is not the same as a barrel available for future use. The revenue is preserved. The resource is still gone.

And here the problem becomes philosophical, because it collides with how economics values the future. Standard practice discounts future costs: a dollar of damage a century from now is worth pennies today. The [Stern Review](#) on climate change used a discount rate of [1.4 percent](#), under which a \$100 benefit a century hence is worth \$24.90 today. [William Nordhaus](#) advocated [4.3 percent](#), under which the same benefit is worth \$1.48. That difference produces radically different policy: Nordhaus proposed a carbon price of [\\$35 per ton](#); Stern recommended [\\$360](#). The dispute is not mathematical. It is moral. Our own impatience — how much we value present consumption over future consumption — is not a reason to discount the needs of people in future generations.

Apply this to residual commons value and the implications are stark. At Nordhaus's discount rate, the interests of a generation born two hundred years from now are worth essentially nothing. Standard discounting does not merely undervalue future generations. At long enough time horizons, it erases them.

[John Rawls](#) proposed that a just policy is one [agreed to from behind a veil of ignorance](#). Apply that veil across time: a policy decided without knowing which generation you will be born into cannot endorse a system that makes your interests worth less simply because you arrive later. If residual commons value were priced under a Rawlsian framework, the price of every barrel of oil, every ton of coal, every ounce of extracted mineral would be vastly higher than any market reflects. The gap between the market price and the Rawlsian price is residual commons value. It is the difference between what we pay and what we owe.

Solving this formally is the work of decades, not paragraphs. But naming the gap is the necessary first step. You cannot solve a problem that has no name.

IV. The Existence Proof

If cost severance were an inevitable law of nature, the framework I have described would be nothing more than a diagnosis. Interesting, perhaps, but useless. You cannot build policy against gravity.

But cost severance is not gravity. It is a choice. And we know this because one country made a different one.

When Norway discovered oil in the North Sea, it faced the same structural pressures that govern resource extraction everywhere: industry demanded rapid drilling, politicians saw

revenues to spend, and the logic of immediate profit argued for maximum-speed extraction. Norway resisted. It imposed heavy taxes on the energy sector, established the [Government Pension Fund Global](#), and instituted a rule that has held across every change of government: no more than three percent of the fund's value can be diverted annually to the national budget. It told oil companies they could not extract immediately. It told taxpayers they would not receive the money right away. It told politicians they could not campaign on spending it.

The fund now holds [\\$2.2 trillion](#) — equivalent to [\\$385,000 for every](#) Norwegian. It generated [\\$247 billion in profit in 2025 alone](#). And critically: the fund now generates far more income than oil production itself. They converted a depleting resource into a permanent income stream and captured the value for their own citizens rather than severing it to distant shareholders.

But I must be honest about Norway's limitations. Norway still extracted the oil. The resource is still permanently gone. And most importantly: Norway had strong democratic institutions, low corruption, and high social trust before the oil was discovered. The preconditions that made Norway's choice possible are precisely the preconditions that Appalachian coal communities have never had. Cost severance does not just transfer costs. It degrades the institutional capacity to resist the transfer. Coal companies fund political campaigns. Extractive industries capture regulatory agencies. The mechanism is self-reinforcing.

V. Accountability and Its Failures

The Deepwater Horizon disaster produced the largest environmental damage settlement in U.S. history — BP's total costs exceeded [\\$65 billion](#). That sounds like accountability. But in a 2012 health settlement, individual payouts amounted to [no more than \\$1,300 each](#) for nearly eighty percent of claimants. Of roughly 4,800 health lawsuits, [all but a handful were dismissed](#). Fifteen years later, effects are still being felt. Congress [did not act](#) on its own bipartisan commission's recommendations. No new drilling safety legislation resulted. The corporation's legal apparatus outlasted the community's capacity to pursue claims. The cost got severed again — through procedural attrition rather than outright abandonment.

What would real accountability look like? Reclamation bonds set by independent assessment at full projected cost before extraction begins, with mandatory annual adjustment — not flat per-acre rates. West Virginia's pool bonds cover ten percent of projected costs. That is not a bonding system. It is a permission slip. Environmental and health obligations that survive corporate dissolution, transferring automatically to independently funded trusts seeded by extraction fees — not evaporating when a company declares bankruptcy. And communities bearing severed costs with funded legal standing to pursue claims — a permanent litigation fund financed by extraction permit surcharges, not pro bono representation that runs out when the firm's budget tightens.

None of these proposals is utopian. Each extends principles that already exist in fragmentary form. The gap between principle and implementation exists because the entities with the power to close it are the same entities that benefit from leaving it open.

VI. Human Scale

By the measures the American economy uses to define success, I succeeded. Four hundred thousand dollars a year. A beautiful house on a square in Savannah's historic district. Healthcare that could handle a catastrophe. I had done what the story of the American dream says you are supposed to do: started with nothing, worked relentlessly, and arrived at something. I was the success story that is supposed to prove the system works. The bootstrap narrative made flesh.

And the system ground me through anyway.

The marriage did not survive. There were reasons beyond the ones I have described here, there always are, but the structural reality was inescapable: the same career that gave us the means to survive a medical crisis required me to be absent for the aftermath. My wife, who came from a family that never went to hospitals, that viewed therapy even showing any emotions at all as a weakness, who had no framework for processing the fact that she had died and been brought back, she needed me there. Not sometimes. There. And the system that captured my value had no mechanism, and no obligation, to account for what my absence would cost. The company that employed me did not end my marriage. But the architecture of high-stakes professional work, the unspoken assumption that the person producing value will simply absorb the personal costs of producing it — made the ending more likely. The cost was never on any company's ledger. But it was definitely carried on mine.

I no longer believe that an extraordinary paycheck justifies uprooting my life. After the marriage ended, I noticed something I had been too busy to see. My parents were not standing as tall as they used to. They are visibly not moving as fast as they used to, and I've done the quiet math that we all eventually do: if I disappear for another few years, surfacing only for weddings and Thanksgivings, the odds are growing that the next flight home will be for something I can't bear to name. So these are the years I have with them, and I intend to be present for them to laugh with them... And to be here for them when there is no laughter left.

That is the real human cost of having every extractable bit of value in you captured by a system that has no mechanism for accounting for what it takes. It is not dramatic. It is not cinematic. It is the slow arithmetic of absence: the holidays missed, the parents unseen, the marriage strained past breaking, the child who learns that his father's presence depends on whether a client deal closed.

So I stopped. I moved home to the Chesapeake Bay. I enrolled in community college. I live on a sailboat. I am pursuing a nursing degree, a career I chose not despite my previous life but because of it. I have worked at Johns Hopkins, Mayo Clinic, and the NIH. I helped design patient registries, clinical trial systems, drug interaction systems and databases. Healthcare was where my work had always felt the most meaningful. Nursing offered something my previous career never could: the ability to stay. To be rooted. To be present for the people and the community that made me who I am while the time to be present still exists. Where on clear evenings I can see the lights of the shipyard where my father's generation built things, and as

the water catches the last light of the day, and the cost of everything I have lost is, for a moment, balanced against the undeniable fact that I am here, and present, and not on a plane.

This is not a solution. Individual opt-outs do not change the mechanism. The miner cannot choose to live on a sailboat. But the impulse reveals that people already understand — in their choices, in the stresses of their daily lives — what this essay is trying to give language to.

VII. Common Bonds

I have used two words throughout this essay — *Commons Bonds* — to name a framework. Bonds as obligations owed to the commons by those who extract from it. Bonds as ties that bind a community to its shared resources. And the echo of financial instruments — collateral that should be posted before extraction begins, priced at the true cost.

But the title has a fourth meaning. Drop a single letter. *Common bonds*.

The Appalachian miner breathing coal dust. The Gulf Coast fisherman whose catch never recovered. The Nigerian villager watching foreign companies pipe crude oil from beneath her community. The tech worker getting on a plane while his wife lies in bed with a wound vac. The eighty-year-old woman working eighty-hour weeks as an unpaid caregiver because the financial architecture valued a procedure at [\\$12.500](#) and the conversation that might have prevented it at [\\$54](#). We do not look alike. We do not vote alike. The system that extracts from us relies on exactly those differences to ensure we never recognize each other. It does not need us to hate one another. It only needs us to never realize that we are standing in the same structural position.

What I am calling for is not revolution. I do not think revolution solves this. The mechanism I have described is older than capitalism and would survive its replacement by any system that does not specifically engineer accountability. What I am calling for is honest accounting: the principle that whoever creates a cost should bear it, that the price of a barrel of oil or a ton of coal or a year of a worker's labor should reflect not just what the market will pay today but what the community and the planet will carry tomorrow.

That is not a left-wing argument. The principle that costs should be borne by those who create them is, in its essence, a conservative one. A person who believes in accountability and personal responsibility should, in principle, agree that a corporation extracting coal from a mountain should be required to pay the full cost of restoring that mountain: not a negotiated fraction of it, not a bond set at rates the industry will accept, but the actual cost. A person who believes in fiscal responsibility should agree that a system allowing companies to generate permanent environmental damage and then dissolve through bankruptcy, leaving the public to pay, is the opposite of fiscal responsibility. The argument is not about redistribution. It is about requiring the price to tell the truth. The principle that costs should be borne by those who create them is, in its essence, a principle of honest dealing.

[Sisyphus](#) was a person in Greek mythology who was cursed to push a boulder up a mountain each day only to have to do it again and again for eternity. Albert Camus asked us [to imagine Sisyphus happy](#). I feel we each push our own boulders. Everyone talks about the big ups and downs. Yet life is really lived in the in-between moments, the steady grind to keep your head above water. The push is not the problem. We are all pushing. The miner and the fisherman and the caregiver and the nursing student: we push, and we find joy in the small things, and we put one foot in front of the other, because that is what you do. I feel that is what Camus meant. You imagine Sisyphus happy not because the boulder cooperates but because you found joy in the defiant act of waking up anew each day and laughing, loving, living — the coffee in the morning, the child's laugh, the evening light on the water — is enough. It has to be enough. It is all we have.

But the boulder should not be heavier than it has to be. And right now, the boulder is loaded with costs that belong to someone else. Every ton of unreclaimed coal waste, every dollar of retirement risk shifted from employer to worker, every hour a parent spends on a plane when they should be at a bedside — these are additions to the boulder that could be prevented. If we named them. If we built structures that made cost severance visible, and then made it expensive, and then made it impossible.

I do not know if we will. But I know that naming the unnamed is how invisible things become visible. And once you finally see it, you cannot unsee it.

One foot in front of the other.

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